



▲ THE FRESH AND SALINE WATERS OF LAKE BALKHASH

Africa. Although relatively small—about 2 miles (4km) of passageways and caverns are known—it is famous for cave paintings dating back to the Early Stone Age and for impressive screens of stalactites, large stalagmites, and other dripstone features. Some of the last bear a resemblance to various figures or structures and have been given individual names, including Madonna and Child, Cleopatra's Needle, Dried Tobacco Leaves, and Leaning Tower of Pisa.

Other rivers and lakes in Africa

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Asia

The Amur

Location From northeast China to the Sea of Okhotsk, eastern Asia

One of Asia's longest rivers, the Amur proper begins at the confluence of the Shilka and Argun (Ergun) Rivers, then flows 1,755 miles (2,824 km) to the Tartar Strait. If the headwaters are included, it is 2,761 miles (4,444 km) long. Its remarkable drainage basin encompasses desert, steppe, taiga, and tundra, and covers an area of 700,000 square miles (1.8 million square km). Fed largely by monsoon rains in summer and fall, the river's waters often rise 46 ft (14 m) above normal at this time, overflowing its banks in the marshy country

downstream of Khabarovsk. For much of its course, the Amur forms the border between China and Russia.

Lake Balkhash

Location Eastern Kazakhstan

The freshwater western section of this vast, shallow lake is separated from the saline eastern section by the Saryesik Peninsula, which almost divides Balkhash in two. The lake narrows and deepens to the east, and there is little mixing between the two parts. Most of the lake's input comes from the Ili River, one of several that drain the mostly arid Balkhash-Alakol Depression (a closed, or endorheic, basin) and discharge into the lake. Balkhash has a surface area of 6,330 square miles (16,400 square km).

The Aral Sea

Location Northern Uzbekistan and southern Kazakhstan

In the 1960s, this endorheic lake was the fourth largest on Earth, with an area of 25,500 square miles (66,000 square km), but it shrank rapidly after its feeder rivers were diverted for irrigation projects. By 2007, its waters had become so shallow that it had split into four lakes, and its surface area was reduced to just one-tenth of what it had once been. Much of what was once water is now desert. Efforts to replenish the waters of the northern section (the North Aral Sea) have succeeded in increasing its surface area and depth, and fish populations are increasing.